



The Great Sandy Desert

An active sandy desert, wetter than the continent's central region, but heat and evaporation steal rain almost as fast as it falls



△ LIFE SUPPORT

An escarpment just above the Oakover River marks the Great Sandy Desert's western edge. The river provides a lifeline for a range of animals.

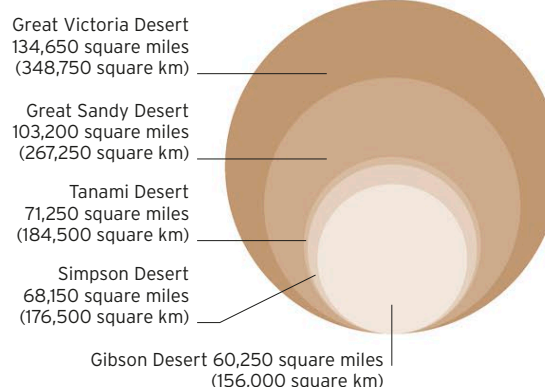
▽ EVER-CHANGING DUNES

The dunes of this desert are thought to have formed about 10,000 years ago. However, constant winds continue to reshape their crests.

Northwest Australia's Great Sandy Desert is bordered to the east by the rocky hills of the Tanami Desert and to the south by the gravelly Gibson. Besides its sand, what makes the Great Sandy different from its neighbors is its climate: the region gets a surprisingly high amount of rain. The average annual rainfall is 10 in (250 mm), even higher in northern sections, and this would normally result in a reasonable amount of plant growth. In the Great Sandy, however, summer daytime temperatures of around 104°F (40°C) mean that evaporation rates are so high that most moisture never has a chance to penetrate the soil. The prevailing winds blow mainly east to west, creating a landscape of constantly shifting red linear sand dunes.

AUSTRALIA'S DESERTS

Deserts make up around one-fifth of Australia's landmass, making it the driest inhabited continent on Earth, but due to their challenging conditions, they are home to less than 3 percent of Australians. The five largest are shown here.



◁ SMALL WONDER

The tiny spinifex hopping mouse has the most efficient kidneys of any mammal, so it can survive without water for long periods.

